

Reading the time

The time can be told by looking carefully at where the hands point on a clock or watch. The hour hand is shorter and moves around slowly. The minute hand is longer than the hour hand and points at minutes "past" the hour or "to" the next one. Most clock faces show the minutes in groups of five and the in-between minutes are shown by a short line or mark. The second hand is usually long and thin, and sweeps quickly around the face every minute, marking 60 seconds.

The short hand indicates what hour it is. This hour hand shows 11.

Between each number is 5 minutes.

The second hand shows 40 seconds on this clock face.

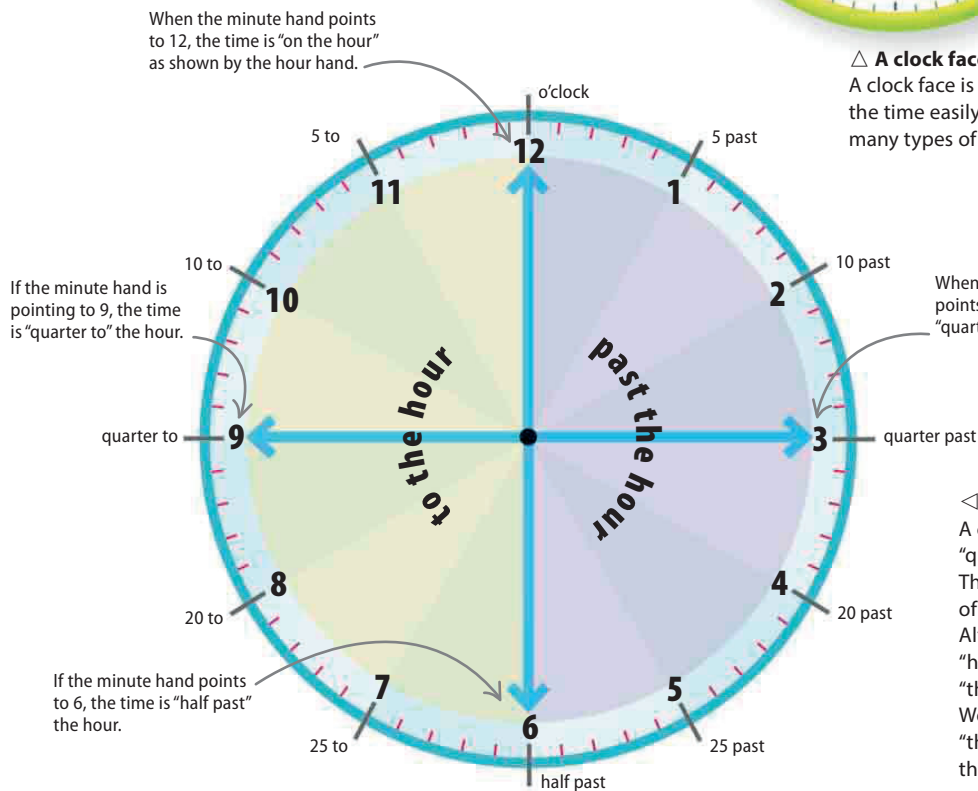
The hands move in this direction. This is called the clockwise direction.

The number of small marks are the number of minutes or seconds.

The long hand shows the minutes. On this clock face 20 minutes have passed.

△ A clock face

A clock face is a visual way to show the time easily and clearly. There are many types of clock and watch faces.



◁ Quarters and halves

A clock can show the time as a "quarter past" or a "quarter to." The quarter refers to a quarter of an hour, which is 15 minutes. Although we say "quarter" and "half," we do not normally say "three-quarters" in the same way. We might say something took "three-quarters of an hour," though, meaning 45 minutes.

